

We have all been there, cruising CNN.com, reading meaningful news, when up pops an ad for an ASOS shirt that we looked at days ago and opted not to buy. We made the sensible decision not to spend, but that discipline has come back to haunt and tease us. For some, these reminders might be enough to spark the urge to return. Laving says, ‘That can be really difficult for people, especially those who have been excessively browsing.’

Inducements from e-boutiques are another temptation. If you browsed an item and moved on, a special deal, discount codes or sale alerts can pop up for that item in your Facebook feed, or in your email inbox if you’re a subscriber to that shopping site. A quick google will show you how to disable cookies and block pop-ups in your phone’s or computer’s settings, and will allow you to find tech whiz reviews for the latest ad-blocking apps.

2. Set browsing boundaries online

Maintain control over your online shopping searches, and don’t let the vortex suck you into spending. Decide on a block of time you’ll dedicate to searching for specific things or just for pleasure, then clap your laptop shut if you don’t find what you’re looking for within that window. ‘Set a time limit, because the internet is boundary-less in terms of time – it is as long as you want to give it,’ Laving says. ‘You might allow yourself to look at two shops and be purposeful about it.’

3. Test yourself

While shopping, stop, with items in hand or lingering in your web cart, and take a moment to answer the following questions – you might find it useful to write them on a slip of paper that slots into your wallet in front of your credit or debit card, or is nestled in with your cash. Laving’s clients receive this ‘reminder card’ in her program:

Understanding your motivation for making the purchase:

- What am I feeling?
- What if I wait?